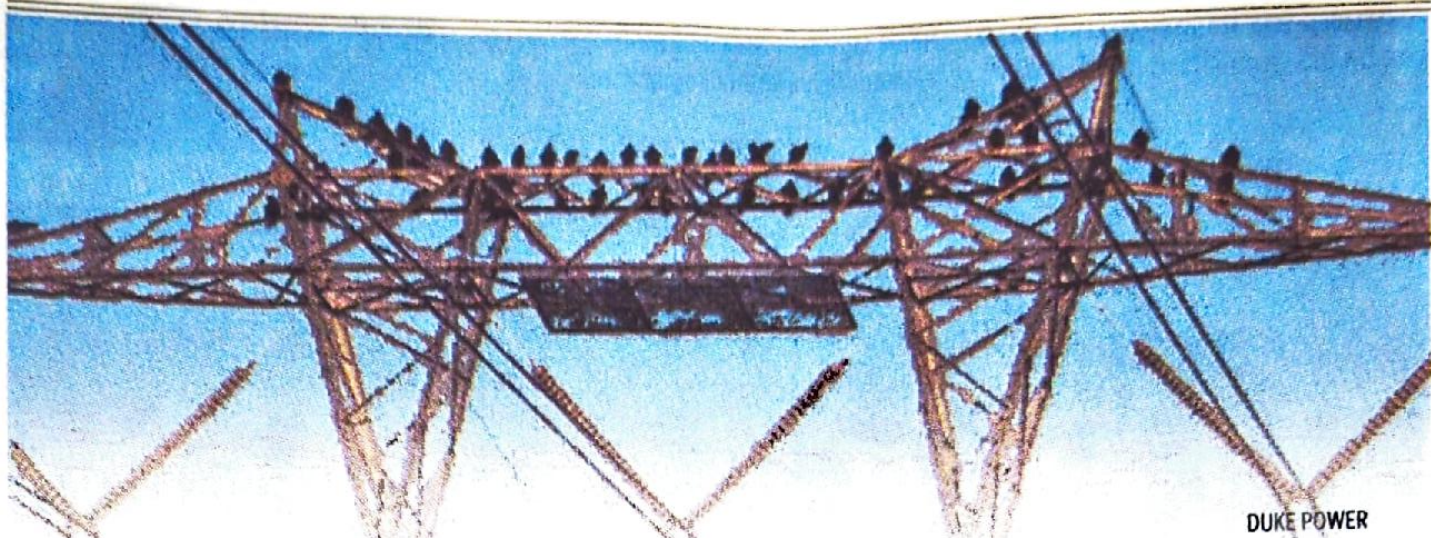




DUKE POWER

Bad habits of birds congregating on Duke Power's towers threaten service.

Duke draws line on ill-mannered guests

Utility finds ways to prevent unpleasant effects of roosting

BY STAN CHOE
Staff Writer

There are the typical challenges of running a power company: hurricanes, blackouts, ice storms.

And then there are the vultures.

The scavengers like to roost atop Duke Power's soaring transmission towers, 150 to 200 feet high. The problem: They vomit and relieve themselves on the towers' insulators, which hang just below and connect the super-juiced power lines to the tower.

The flung fluids conduct electricity, and they can short

out the lines, which run to some of Duke's biggest customers. And those customers expect the lights to turn on at each flip of the switch.

Poisoning or shooting vultures is outlawed. So first the company tacked stuffed owls on the towers' tops in the early 1980s to frighten the vultures. Instead, the birds snuggled up to their stuffed friends.

Later, Duke installed a Plexiglas shield under the roosts to deflect the liquid bombs. That worked for a while, but the shields began cracking.

Two years ago, the company switched to harder plastic shields under the center of the roosting area.

On the tower's far ends, six-inch stainless-steel spikes keep birds away.

The price to defend a tower is \$5,000 to \$10,000; Duke has already fitted about 100.

It's been so successful, Ra-

leigh-based CP&L has hired Duke to do some of its transmission towers.

The stronger shields and spikes have done the trick. Duke reports fewer outages. But it doesn't need to upgrade its 2,400 other 525,000-kilovolt Carolinas towers, because the vultures tend to stick around the same 100 locations.

In roosting, vultures care about proximity to two things: landfills or roadkill.

And they're the only birds that pose this problem for Duke. While most expel waste away from themselves, vulture droppings shoot directly down, said Betty O'Leary of the Carolina Raptor Center. The bald birds conserve heat by white-washing their legs, she said.

As for the vomit, the relatively weak-winged birds occasionally get stressed and dump their carrion baggage for an easier takeoff.

Charlotte
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